

A Personal Story

Lived experience of the AISH to ADAP transition

Dear Friends, Neighbors, and Community,

I am writing this because I need to share the raw, unvarnished truth of what my life looks like right now. For a long time, I have carried the weight of a changing body, fading independence, and a daily reality that is as terrifying as it is exhausting. I am breaking my silence because hiding the hard parts doesn't make them go away, and if we are going to talk about chronic illness and disability, we need to talk about what it actually looks like in the dark.

This is what my life looks like now. I am 54 years old. I have been trapped in this downward health spiral since 2017, watching my body and life slowly unravel for nearly a decade. My diagnosis is a heavy, overlapping web: Fibromyalgia, Chronic Fatigue Syndrome, and a chronic pain syndrome that feels like it has no end. It all started to snowball after an accident, a single injury, and I have never been the same since.

That is the terrifying truth people don't want to look at: we are all just one illness or injury away from being disabled. We take things for granted every single day until we suddenly don't have those things anymore. And then, instead of receiving compassion, we are judged for being lazy and accused of robbing a system, when the reality is that we have been robbed of absolutely everything but our dignity.

I've only been attached to the system and on AISH since 2023. Recently, I was completely displaced within the system, moved out of AISH and into ADAP without any explanation, no structure, and absolutely nothing explained to me except the devastating news that we were going to get less. Just cast aside by a bureaucracy that leaves me completely in the dark, forced to figure out how to survive with even less support.

The bureaucratic warfare isn't just frustrating; it is lethal. The system doesn't support us; it tests us until we break. That is exactly why we lost Bruce Johnson. He was a human being who simply could not handle the cruelty and the crushing weight of this system anymore. When the announcement of ADAP threatened to pull his safety net away, the anxiety, stress, and despair pushed him past his absolute breaking point. His death is a tragic, direct indictment of what happens when a government decides to experiment on the lives of its most vulnerable citizens.

And the truth is, it's only been since I've been on AISH that I have become almost homeless twice. Twice, I was within 24 hours of having absolutely nowhere to stay, and things only came through by a pure miracle and a blessing because of the sheer mountain of red tape, hoops, and barriers you have to jump through just to get emergency assistance. It's not that I don't appreciate the help; I do. I appreciate everything they give me, and I ask them for very little to begin with. But for the most part, the system is just not client-friendly. Maybe some of the workers are just completely burnt out, I don't know. Some of them are amazing, but the stress of dealing with the rest of it is crushing.

Now, with this abrupt shift, I have no idea what these people for ADAP are going to be like. Maybe it will be some of the original AISH staff who understand, or maybe it will just be more confusion. I just

don't know.

My daily life is dictated by a strict boundary of physical limitation. My entire exertion limit, my baseline for what my body can physically handle, is defined by navigating exactly 6 stairs, a platform, and doing that three times. That is my mountain. To cross that line means paying a massive price. When I overexert myself, I am met with intense shortness of breath, a deep, gasping "puffing" that leaves me completely drained.

Even the place I live now is a testament to this lack of choice. Because of my severe mobility issues, I am not supposed to be on stairs at all, not a single one. Yet, I am forced to live in a place with stairs because it was the only place that would rent to me within my absolute survival budget.

The physical cost of simply trying to survive these stairs is destroying my body. I already have to get routine pain management injections in both of my knees and my left arm just to keep moving. But now, because of the grueling, daily physical battle of trying to tackle these stairs and haul myself up and down, my right arm is giving out too. I am now forced to start getting pain injections in my right arm as well, just from the sheer strain of fighting my way up to my own front door.

Because of this severe breakdown, I have actually lived as a complete shut-in for about three years now. My world has shrunk entirely down to my immediate surroundings, and absolutely everything, from my prescriptions to the food basket, must be delivered directly to my door. Every single essential has to be brought to me. The delivery drivers have to carry it from the main entrance all the way to my door because I am not even physically able to carry my own prescriptions.

Inside my home, the loss of independence is total. The things healthy people take for granted are monumental hurdles for me. I am entirely unable to cook basic meals. Even a task as simple as cleaning a few dishes is an agonizing struggle that leaves me spent. The immense amount of energy it takes to have a bath or a shower is often entirely out of reach, forcing me to rely on baby wipes just to maintain basic hygiene.

Because of this reality, I know with absolute certainty that I will live out my life alone, surviving as independently as possible. I carry profoundly embarrassing symptoms, and I refuse to become a burden to anyone else. Because the hard, brutal truth of our society is that the moment you become unemployable, you are instantly viewed as a burden. Rather than subject anyone to that weight, I hold my boundaries within these walls.

The fragility of my survival was driven home in the starkest way possible when I was rushed to the hospital in late winter. This spring has been a blur of cardiac clinics, specialists, and constant, terrifying uncertainty. I have spent my months with a cardiologist, having my heart monitored repeatedly to figure out why my system is failing so hard. While the cardiologist confirmed I don't need immediate, invasive interventions like a stent, the hard medical truth from my testing shows a frighteningly high risk, I could have a heart attack or a stroke within the near future if I don't get things entirely under control. To try and keep me alive, my doctor and I are now trying to navigate a strict diet and a whole new regimen of preventative medications, while having to fight the system just to see what basic health benefits will actually be covered.

Alongside the cardiac testing, I had a home sleep test done that brought a whole new layer of danger: I have a level of sleep apnea that sits just on the razor-edge before severe. But the system forces you to wait even when your life is on the line. I cannot even get a CPAP machine to help me breathe at night until I complete an overnight, Level 1 clinic sleep study. I was told there is a standard, agonizing two-year wait list just to get a spot in a clinic. Because of my severe limitations, I am entirely dependent on a local lab in Edmonton so I can take a cab door-to-door, as the thought of transportation out of the city is impossible. Until my name is pulled from that massive wait list, or until my doctor can successfully push the system to triage my cardiac risks as urgent, I am stuck waiting in the dark.

When I have to leave for medical reasons, I only leave by cab to go straight to the doctor and straight back. It is strictly door-to-door. I cannot wait around or risk any complications happening while I am out. Outside of those medical appointments, I am only forcing myself to leave my property two times a month. When I do, it is a deliberate, focused effort: I go to where there are woods and trees, always with family members supervising me, so that I can safely try to increase my strength, my longevity, and my capabilities of mobility.

But even these rare, vital trips to the closest park require an overwhelming amount of exhausting preparation. Because I am completely unable to physically defend myself, and I refuse to expect my teenage grandchildren or whoever is with me to do it for me, I have to bring a duffel bag packed for every worst-case scenario. Of course, I can't physically carry the duffel bag myself, I have to strap it onto my walker just to move it. It is loaded with protection, everything from dog spray to specific safety keychains to keep us secure. It has to hold water, my Pedialyte, a first aid kit, a backup battery pack so my phone never dies in an emergency, and pain patches to slap all over my body the second a symptom acts up.

That bag also has to be packed with snacks, because if my body begins to get too tired or too sore while I am out, I have no choice but to stop and rest right there until I can find the strength to get back home. I don't have the luxury of calling a cab to pick me up from the park when my body crashes; I cannot afford it. Every single cent of that transportation budget has to be fiercely guarded and saved for essential medical travel only. I have to be entirely prepared for disaster before it even happens, just to sit near the trees.

The preparation isn't just about safety from others; it is driven by a deep, paralyzing terror. My biggest fear in the whole entire world isn't being rejected by potential employers. I've already been down that road, and I know exactly what is going to happen there. No, my biggest fear, the one that has always haunted me, is being out in public, collapsing, and suddenly finding myself flat on the ground, looking up at complete strangers touching my body. As a survivor, the thought of being helpless, surrounded, and handled by people I don't know scares the absolute hell out of me. It is why leaving my home feels like stepping into a minefield.

Over the past three years, I have worked extremely hard within these brutal boundaries to build my strength, pushing my daily steps up from a baseline of just 400 to 1,400 steps. It is a grueling, slow-won victory that took years of agonizing effort, but it is a testament to how hard I try to keep moving forward.

Because of this, I have had to reframe how I view my time. I have had to consciously stop looking at periods of physical inactivity as a failure, and instead view them as "Tactical Recovery." My motto for this year has become "Pace, Not Race," because racing is a luxury my body no longer affords me.

When I am within my walls, my life revolves around "nesting." On a rare day that is simply "a day," I won't call it a good day, just a day, the nesting is a bit less. But when I know I am completely stuck and a flare is taking over, I have to nest intensely, surrounding myself with every survival item, medication, and comfort I need within arm's reach because I won't be able to get back up.

Tactical recovery is a battleground of symptoms. If I close my eyes right now and do a mental body scan, it doesn't bring calm, it feels like watching a terrifying display of fireworks going off all at once. Every single system is firing a different kind of distress signal. There are the sharp, stabbing pains, the deep, heavy aches, the burning sensations, and scary, tight chest pains that make it hard to catch my breath. There is the relentless nausea that leads to vomiting, leaving me dry-heaving and completely spent.

My whole entire body is under siege. I am constantly battling migraines that blind me, severe acid reflux, and Irritable Bowel Syndrome (IBS). My lymphatic system is sluggish and overwhelmed. I deal with structural breakdown, including arthritis throughout my body and severe degenerative arthritis in my lower back and the left side of my chest. On top of the chronic conditions, my immune system is so vulnerable and compromised by immune disease that even acute infections like strep throat rip right through me. And since COVID, my ability to smell is almost completely gone, erasing another basic piece of how I experience the world.

My winters are horrible and full of cold pain, but then the summer comes and my body dehydrates so severely that I have a running prescription for six bottles of Pedialyte at a time. To manage all of this, I take booklets of prescriptions. It is literally bound like a book. I take 11 pills just in the morning dosage, 3 at lunch, another 4 or 5 at supper, and another 4 and a half at bedtime. And that doesn't even include the whole new hormone therapy, the injections for pain, the B12 shots, and the endless, overlapping side effects of all these medications. Honestly, I don't even know what side effect belongs to what drug anymore.

And it isn't just physical; my mind is trapped in this war zone too, carrying the heavy, exhausting weights of post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and constant anxiety. You name the symptom, and my body is cycling through it. Because I know I have to be mentally well to even begin taking care of the physical, I am pushing this week to dig into the root of my mental struggles. I have an appointment scheduled to see if I have ADHD, autism, or whatever else is misfiring in my brain, alongside an appointment with an unknown psychiatrist just to touch base and find a way to anchor myself through this incredibly stressful time.

I suffer from severe autonomic issues where my body completely loses its ability to regulate temperature. I experience sudden, intense episodes of "pooling" sweats, even while I am just resting or trying to listen to music. These sweats are immediately followed by deep, agonizing chills and rigors in my limbs, a cold that feels like it settles deep into my skin and bones.

And then there are the parts that are incredibly difficult to talk about. The parts wrapped in shame that I am choosing to lay bare anyway. My illness has progressed to the point of causing physical indignities, including recent episodes of anal leakage and incontinence, especially during or after times of physical stress. Dealing with skin barrier ointments, laundry, and basic hygiene when my pain is sitting at a 6 or higher out of 10 is an overwhelming hill to climb.

The systemic cruelty of trying to get help for these indignities has left me entirely broken. When I asked Aids to Daily Living for support, they told me they would not give me diapers because I didn't poop myself enough times a day to qualify under their strict criteria. They informed me that I had to get AISH to pay for them instead. Because I like a paper trail, especially because when these agencies want to do something shady, they always prefer to do it over a phone call, I reached out to AISH by email. Sure enough, an AISH worker called me back instead of replying to my email. Over the phone, the worker told me to call back Aids to Daily Living and lie through my teeth to get the funding through them, because AISH wasn't going to do it.

I refused. Doing that would have made me look dishonest across the entire system. Because I chose integrity, I am forced to find my diapers at yard sales, thrift stores, food banks, or I simply end up throwing away a lot of ruined underwear.

Living like this carries a heavy weight of risk. Because of a long-term medication regimen that includes Tramadol and Ativan, combined with my deep sleep cycles and severe symptomatic episodes, independent living has become genuinely dangerous for me. I don't currently have a medical alert button. In the meantime, I survive by carrying my phone with me everywhere I go, and I have an emergency whistle that I keep on hand to use as an emergency alarm. It is terrifying, and it is far from ideal, but it is all I have right now to keep from struggling or falling entirely alone.

Beyond the physical toll, the truest, heaviest weight of this illness is the profound, relentless wave of loss. It has taken pieces of my life one by one, leaving me to grieve a world that kept moving forward without me. I have lost my employment, the purpose, structure, and financial stability that came with it. Almost my entire employment background was in waitressing, being around food, and serving people. If I can no longer walk properly, if my hands are giving out, and I can't even smell the food I am supposed to be around, what am I honestly supposed to do? When my prescriptions and baseline medical treatments fall completely short, I am forced to pay entirely out of pocket for CBG, CBN, and CBD products just to try and taper off the agonizing pain when the prescription medication isn't doing its job. I have lost my social life, as the world shrinks down to the four walls of my room. I have lost my spouse, a devastating fracturing of partnership and connection.

Every single inch of my body craves the life I used to have. If I could snap my fingers and get it back, don't people think I would? It's not like I get to do much of anything anyway; if I could work or be out in the world, I would give anything to have that.

There are days upon days where the illness wins completely, and I am trapped in bed, simply too sick to function, watching the clock tick by, and feeling the sheer weight of losing so much of my existence. It is an ache that goes beyond the physical pain; it is the grief of watching your former life disappear while you are still here to witness it.

The financial strain of this isolation has forced me to the absolute brink. My rent takes up a staggering 54% of my income, and that was before they cut my funding by 200 dollars, and before dealing with ADAP more financial cuts. Fighting for that very funding was its own nightmare. When I first applied for AISH, they denied me the exact same week that Aids to Daily Living approved and delivered my heavy equipment: a walker that converts to a wheelchair, an upright bed pole, a raised toilet seat with safety bars for when my knees lock, and a transfer bench for the bathtub. The sheer devastation of having one agency provide all the gear for a severe disability, while the agency meant to sustain me told me I wasn't "disabled enough," was crushing.

Out of absolute despair, I actually contacted MAID (Medical Assistance in Dying). I filled out the forms. When they finally sent a message back, it went to an old email linked to my phone that I rarely checked. I didn't see it until months later. When I opened it, I realized they hadn't approved me at all; they had just responded to my initial email with basic information packet links. Thankfully, by some twist of fate, I missed that message during my darkest moment, and the process stopped there, so I am still here.

When I kept fighting for AISH, the system fought back with incompetence. They kept losing my doctor's paperwork during Covid. By the time it was finally pushed through, the system owed me \$10,000 in backpay. Instead of paying what they owed, they forced me to alter the dates on my paperwork to match the doctor's timeline just so they would finally process it. In the end, I was shortchanged and received only \$2,000 instead of the \$10,000. The Edmonton Legal Centre helped me through the appeal and asked if I wanted to legally pursue the rest of the money they stole from me. I said no. Growing up, I had it literally beaten into me: you don't bite the hand that feeds you. I was too terrified of losing what little I had left.

Because of this extremely low income, I am forced to stay in areas that are not desirable, which places me in constant, direct danger. It is incredibly risky for me to even step outside my door at times; when people see me out with my walker, they immediately assume that I must be carrying heavy prescription medications. Because of this visible vulnerability, I have been targeted and harassed by drug seekers in the past.

Yet, I cannot live in a roommate situation to save money. I tried living in a boarding house once, and the other tenants all ended up being drug users. I absolutely need a place by myself just to keep myself slightly functioning well sometimes. I cannot handle the added burden, stress, and confusion of other people being in my space, especially on my hard flare days, weeks, or months.

The road to finding even this roof over my head was paved with exploitation and trauma. When navigating the rental market on a disabled budget, I was met with predators. I had men respond to my rental inquiries expecting me to pay rent and share their one-bedroom bed with them. These men do this repeatedly because they know eventually they will find someone hurting so badly and so desperate for shelter that they will agree to lay with a stranger. But as a survivor of molestation and rape, I cannot do that. I cannot compromise my sanity or my safety like that.

When I tried renting from private landlords, the exploitation just took different forms. In one place, an upstairs tenant literally kept my walker hostage so that I would be forced to act as an indentured

babysitter. In another place, the landlord got deep into gambling debts; even though I paid my rent early every single month, she suddenly started demanding it even earlier and demanding more money, using the excuse that my grandkids stayed with me for a month in the summer.

Because of that greed, I lost my home. I moved into my current building out of a desperate hope for safety. I am on the top floor now. Even though it means facing the agony of stairs every single day, and carrying physical injuries from falling or just trying to haul my walker up and down them, I chose it for survival. Up here, intruders have to go through a lot of people before they can get to me. It is safety in numbers.

My budget is so broken that I've had to stop buying fresh fruits and vegetables entirely, living instead off things like peanut butter, tuna, and eggs when I can get them. It has driven me to the point of absolute desperation, like the time when rotten grocery store food that was originally supposed to go to farm animals was redirected so that myself and people like me could pick through the rotten pig slop just to find something edible.

Because of these extreme financial limits and changing support, I am also having to reconsider whether I can even keep my animals, the very creatures who are the only "people" I see on a regular basis. I am having to reconsider whether I can afford to keep the internet, even though it is my only lifeline for online medical appointments, courses, and research.

When the darkness of all of this becomes too heavy, I find myself looking outward. I have always felt a deep, spiritual kinship with trees. They are my ultimate confidants, holders of my "inner bark" stories, offering a shared silence and a validation of my existence. I look at them as the ultimate transmuters, they take what is toxic and turn it into life-giving oxygen. They have a structural integrity that allows them to absorb the darkness without letting it become their entire identity. Lately, I have been leaning against them, letting my own darkness leak out, giving them something to ground, and letting them help me drain the toxicity of this illness into the earth where it can finally be still. I am even facing the heartbreaking reality that I am probably going to lose my elm tree soon, a loss that feels deeply personal.

If we are going to talk about chronic illness, trauma, and disability under the poverty line, we need to talk about the terrifying reality that the system is built to break you before it ever decides to help you. We need to talk about what happens when the very safety net you fought years to reach is suddenly pulled out from under your feet.

The calculation of this systemic cruelty is endless. They see that the federal government finally stepped in to give disabled people a \$200 benefit, and the provincial response is to instantly turn around, strip another \$200 away from us on the provincial side, and try to force us out to look for work. But it is a trap. The rules are built so that if we do manage to push our broken bodies to earn a little bit of income, we are penalized so heavily that we end up making far less take-home money than what we would have had if we just stayed on basic AISH benefits. Every single aspect of this system is designed to squeeze us down to less, and less, and less. And if you happen to be a couple trying to survive together, they punish you even more brutally, shaving away your safety until there is nothing left.

And the politicians hide behind deadlines to avoid looking at the human wreckage they are creating. They keep giving speeches saying, "Oh, but we aren't going to officially drop your rates and make it less until December 2027." They say it like it's a favor. But they never stop to answer the real, terrifying question: what do they expect thousands of severely disabled human beings to do when January comes? What are we supposed to do in the bitter, freezing cold of a northern winter, when we wake up on New Year's Day and suddenly find that our absolute baseline survival money is just gone?

The system claims this shift is to push us toward employment, but the sheer anxiety of looking for work is paralyzing when you look at the reality of what your day actually requires. I had an AISH worker call me out of the blue, and when they call, you have to answer the phone, it's mandatory. The moment I picked up, without him knowing a single thing about the actual depths of my medical file, he said, "Well, you answered the phone, so obviously you can work at a call center." The casual ignorance is sickening. How am I supposed to navigate a job like that when I cannot even do something as simple as go get dental surgery without full adult supervision, and without facing the physical indignity of defecating on myself while simply getting my teeth looked at? Demanding compliance or forcing people to navigate administrative warfare when their bodies are in this level of active crisis pushes human beings past their absolute breaking point, trapping them in a constant state of fight-or-flight.

When you live under the poverty line with a disability, you aren't just fighting a war against your own malfunctioning body. You are fighting a war against a rigid, cold system that demands total compliance, rewards dishonesty, and punishes integrity, all while shaving away the pennies you need to stay alive.

All we ask at the very end of saying all this is not to do ADAP. Get rid of ADAP. It is a program that is already costing lives. Instead, fix and work on the AISH program. The bones of it are good. The structure is there, it just needs to be properly funded, managed with humanity, and built to actually support the people who rely on it to stay alive.

I am sharing all of this, from my schedules to my leaky butt, from being pushed from AISH to ADAP with zero explanation, from three continuous years of living like a shut-in to the firework display of pain, from the terrifyingly close calls with homelessness to the predatory housing offers, from the duffel bag packed with snacks and protection strapped to my walker to the pain injections destroying my joints just to climb the stairs, from workers making assumptions about my ability to work a call center job just because I answered a mandatory phone call, from having to buy my own out-of-pocket CBG, CBN, and CBD products just to survive the gaps when medication fails, from the systemic pressure of workers telling me to lie to get basic hygiene supplies to the traumatic reality of needing supervision and risking incontinence just to see a dentist, from the daily fight to cook, clean, or even bathe without exhausting my entire reservoir of strength, from the terrifying hospital rushes and the looming threat of a heart attack or stroke hanging over my head while I navigate a standard two-year lab wait list right here in Edmonton, from my appointments to check for ADHD and autism alongside a new psychiatrist to manage this situational trauma, from the severe reality of living with immune disease alongside chronic illness, to the sudden trauma of a single injury that snowballed into a lifetime of Fibromyalgia and Chronic Fatigue, to the tragic reality of system failures that took Bruce Johnson away from us, from the cold math of a bureaucracy that leaves us freezing and cut off in the dead of

winter, from the primal fear of collapsing helplessly in public to the compounding grief of all these losses, because I want everything recorded. I want my kids to see the truth of what I fought through. I want my local government and community to understand why disabled aids, financial safety, proper nutrition, and physical support aren't luxuries; they are survival.

This is my realness at 54. It is messy, it is embarrassing, and it is scary. But it is my truth, and I thank you for hearing it.

With love and hope for gentler days,

(name as the author wishes, or left anonymous)